

Be a Competitor: Set High Goals, featuring Phillip Fulmer

Coach Phillip Fulmer

My good friend, Pat Summitt, had a favorite quote ...

Coach Pat Summitt

“Competitiveness is not the most sociable quality you can possess, but competitiveness is what separates achievers from the average. Only by learning to compete can you discover just how much you are capable of achieving. Too many people elect to be average out of timidity. As I look around, I see scores of underachievers. The world is full of them.”

Coach Phillip Fulmer

A competitive spirit won't always win friends, but it will earn respect. People limit themselves when they choose being timid over tenacity. While it's natural to hold a desire for acceptance, if you let that desire dictate everything you do, you may find yourself compromising your own ambitions for approval. The ultimate goal of competition is not popularity, it's winning.

When you apply yourself fully toward the accomplishment of your goals, you orient yourself toward success no matter what the cost. Success generates credibility, and if people see results, they will be more likely to respect and trust you in your leadership. Pat Summitt was as tough as they came, and she expected the same toughness from her players. Her 1987 team drove her crazy with how polite they were to each other on the court. Pat needed them to stop playing nice. The 1987 team got the message. Their toughness earned the Lady Vols their first NCAA championship.

Winners aim high and true. Competitors never settle. They don't wait for success to just manifest. They push themselves to go after their goals. The way Pat thought about it was, “People rise to the level of their own expectations and of the competition they seek out.” You put your toughness to the test when you continually set new goals that push your limits and raise the bar of expectation.

Pat was intense with the physical demands she required from her players because she believed it was crucial for them to learn how to dig deeper.

Coach Pat Summitt

“People are afraid to make a mistake or to fail or to be wrong. They're afraid to find out what's inside of them. Competitiveness is the opposite of complacency. It's uncomfortable. It requires commitment and risk and soul-searching. When you choose to compete, you take a huge gamble. You might just lose. You might just have to admit, ‘That's the best I can do.’”

Coach Phillip Fulmer

Oftentimes, what you perceive to be a limit of your own grit and endurance is really just a self-imposed ceiling. When you push yourself to exceed your perceived limits, you develop mental fortitude and inner strength. Both are fundamental to being a competitor.